cals. He was out on bail and opening his store on the morning of November 10 when half a dozen assailants opened fire on him. Suri, a readymade garment retailer, was the leader of Punjab-based Shiv Sena (Taksali) and had been openly challenging Sikh radicals and the Khalistan movement. Police have arrested his assailant Sandeep Singh, a.k.a. Sunny, who shot him dead with a licensed weapon outside a temple in Amritsar on November 4. The two murders bring back memories of a series of targeted killings in Punjab in 2016-17, in which the victims included Hindu right-wing leaders, Dera Sacha Sauda followers and a Christian pastor. Security agencies see the murders as a part of the same radical agenda.

The probe into Suri's murder has also brought up the name of Amritpal Singh Sandhu, who mysteriously entered the state's religio-political scene a couple of months back and is being called Bhindranwale 2.0 because of his likeness to the Sikh militant leader killed in Operation Bluestar. According to the police, a video has surfaced in which Suri's assassin and Sandhu can be seen together. Even as Sandhu has denied any role in the Hindu leader's murder, he has justified the killing. "Suri was constantly speaking against Sikhs, *tahiye sodhiya gaya* (that's why he was punished)," he said. *Sodhiya*, a Punjabi word for punished, was frequently used during the militancy era in the state.

Sandhu, 29, moved back to Punjab only in August—after having stayed in Dubai for a decade—and took over the reins of Waris Punjab De, an advocacy group launched by late actor and activist Deep Sidhu to 'fight for legitimate demands of the people of Punjab'. Sidhu, who had gained prominence during the agitation against the now-repealed agricultural laws, had died in a car crash in February. Sandhu was anointed the head of the group on September 29, the first anniversary of its formation, during a mega event organised at Rode village in Moga district. The choice of the venue was quite strategic, as it is the ancestral village of Bhindranwale. Just like him, Sandhu too wears a blue round turban, carries a small *kirpan* slung across his white robe and makes fiery speeches that have garnered him a following among radical Sikh youths. He has been attending and addressing several religious congregations, their videos regularly shared on social media.

The ban on the public display of weapons appears to be in response to Sandhu's call to Sikh youths to get baptised and carry a *kirpan* or other licensed arms. Openly asking the youths to lay down their lives to "break the shackles of slavery", he has repeatedly warned of "bloodshed" for the cause of a separate Sikh nation—Khalistan. It's not yet clear if Sandhu will adhere to the AAP government's diktat on arms. He has remained defiant so far, and could use this as an opportunity to take on the state and increase his influence among the youth, say political observers who have been closely watching his rise.

But how has a 29-year-old, who just moved back to Punjab, been able to carve a niche in the state's *panthic* (related to Sikh community) politics? Observers feel he has done so by rapidly capturing the space vacated by the moderates. After the restructuring of the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) in 1995, the moderate faction led by Parkash Singh Badal had captured most of the *panthic* political space. Most hardliners, such as Simranjit Singh Mann and Gurcharan Singh Tohra, were either marginalised or pushed into oblivion. But the fortunes have rapidly changed

THE PUNJAB GOVT HAS BANNED THE PUBLIC DISPLAY OF WEAPONS AND SONGS THAT GLORIFY GUN CULTURE

MURDERS MOST FOUL

Two broad daylight murders in a week in Punjab raise the spectre of radicals becoming active again

NOV. 4

Hindu right-wing leader Sudhir Suri, who had been openly challenging Sikh radicals, was shot dead outside a temple in Amritsar. According to police, assailant Sandeep Singh, who had opened fire with a licensed weapon, was 'radicalised'

NOV. 10

Pradeep Kataria, a Dera Sacha Sauda follower who was accused of sacrilege, died after six men opened fire on him outside his dairy store in Kotkapura. A cop deployed for his security and a passerby were also injured



ANI

CAUGHT ON CAMERA Shiv Sena (Taksali) leader Sudhir Suri was shot dead in Amritsar on Nov. 4